grieving in Kalanaur, Hemu had wasted no time at all. He had marched out of Chunar, the headquarters of Adil Shah, and had stormed and taken Agra. Gathering the enemies of the Mughals, who were legion, into his own army, Hemu then marched on Delhi itself.

Hemu, a Hindu of the Baniya caste, was an unlikely hero in an age of giants. He began life obscurely enough as a petty trader but caught the attention of Adil Shah, and slowly gained prestige through his shrewd intelligence, industry, and honesty. Abu'l Fazl was notoriously scathing of this first great adversary of Akbar's and railed that 'outwardly he had neither rank…nor race…nor beauty of form…nor noble qualities'. No doubt Abu'l Fazl was piqued by this man of obscure origins who had the ambition to challenge Akbar when he was at his most vulnerable. Abu'l Fazl fulminated that it was through 'evil speaking, plotting and calumny' that Hemu rose to become prime minister but there is little doubt that Hemu, while apparently a man of underwhelming physical stature, was one of considerable acumen and skill, and even Abu'l Fazl had to admit that 'ill-starred' though he was, Hemu had already won twenty-two battles against powerful amirs. Realizing that the young Mughal Padshah was far away, and that the city was under the nominal charge of Tardi Beg, Hemu seized his chance and marched towards Delhi.

Delhi, as well as the northern cities of Agra and Bayana, in addition to Gujarat, were reeling under the catastrophic effects of a famine and the consequent epidemics of two successive years between 1554 and 1556, leading to political chaos. 'Men of wealth and position had to close their houses,' wrote Badauni, sixteen years old at the time, 'and died by tens or twenties or even more in one place, getting neither grave nor shroud.' These dead included Hindus as well as Muslims and those who survived were reduced to living on 'the seeds of the Egyptian thorn, wild dry grass and cowhides'. 'The writer of these pages,' continued Badauni, 'with these guilty eyes of his saw man eating his fellow-man in those terrible days'. Brought on by drought and crop failure, these were 'two years [of] continual anarchy and terror…and lawless crowds attacked the cities of the Muslims'. Abu'l Fazl also wrote about the epidemics, noting the plague that spread as a result of the mounds of the dead and the marauding parties being formed to seize and eat solitary victims.

But as Hemu rode towards Delhi with his enormous army of 50,000 cavalry and 500 elephants, the soldiery and the animals continued to find